

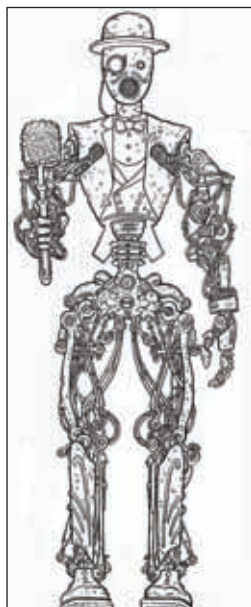
Self-awareness and robot uprising

Umpteen science fiction novels and films deal with one central theme: the ability of artificial intelligence to become self-aware. From *I Robot* to *The Terminator*, it's a recurrent theme that's been approached seemingly from every angle.

Yet self-awareness itself seems to bifurcate into two broad categories: an outcome of androids wanting to live with humanity and a scenario where robots seem to think humanity is a threat and decide to eliminate mankind. And this result often seems intertwined with the series of events that led to the robot's self-awareness, leading to a cause-and-effect scenario that artificial intelligence experts argue against.

Let's take the "good" outcome where a self-aware AI wants to live with humans. *The Bicentennial Man* explored this concept in great detail as the robot, Andrew, learns more and more traits that are decidedly "human" and slowly starts becoming self-aware. But it's the continuing support of his human "family" that pushes him to explore more about himself and learn more in the process, making the scenario one where he strives to co-exist with humanity and be accepted as one. In his quest to be accepted as a human being, he finally realises that the only way to do that is to push his positronic brain to a point of decay, thus giving up the concept of immortality to become truly human. It's a philosophical and introspective inquest into self-awareness.

And then there's the "bad" not self-aware AI, as shown in *The Terminator* or *The Matrix* series. In each, the sequence of events leading up to the AI wanting to destroy mankind seems reactionary vengeance. In *The Terminator*, for instance, the super-computer Skynet is developed to be an intelligent system in charge of all the defence mechanisms of mankind. This way, the reaction to any threat is ensured to be logical and swift rather than compromised by human indecision. But as Skynet evaluates more problems and starts becoming more self-aware, its makers start fearing it and decide to unplug it. This triggers off a self-defence



B166ER kills its master as an act of self-defense